



Key persons at Open-Silicon to attend a course in 'Managing at the Top' at IIM Bangalore in 2006 with Chitra Hariharan (second from left)

you get there," he advises. "Many people wait for a promotion before they start acting like a leader. That is the wrong approach. The best way to advance is to start doing the work of the next level before you are officially given the title." This philosophy shaped his career in the years to come.

Alongside a colleague, Balasubramaniam, he started a side business designing electronic doorbells. Utilising reverse engineering, he expanded into designing other products, developing a deeper understanding of how to build and innovate. "That was my first experience with product design—taking something apart, understanding it, and then improving it," he says.

Amidst all this, he was focused on his goal of studying in the US and managed to save up to ₹32,000 in two years. He dedicated himself to preparing for the Graduate Record Examinations, improving his vocabulary by studying through flashcards while travelling to work. He scored well on the GRE on his second try and secured a scholarship to pursue his master's degree at the University of Louisiana in Lafayette.

Surviving the American Dream

In 1989, two years after starting his job at HCL, he finally set foot in the

United States, closer to his dream of touching the New York skyline—a new chapter in his journey. Taher's life in the US was no American dream but another battle of survival. The scholarship covered tuition, but he had to figure out a way to sustain himself again.

"When I arrived in the US, I had to start from scratch—find students to tutor, manage finances, and adjust to an entirely different culture. But I had already done this before. I had rebuilt my life in Calcutta and then in Aligarh. This was just another challenge," he reflects.

Once again, teaching became his lifeline. Amongst his students at the university was an elderly gentleman pursuing an MBA, a man almost his father's age. "He struggled with math—vector multiplication and other concepts that were completely foreign to him, and reached out to me for tutoring," Taher recalls.

The student soon became Taher's family in the foreign land. "He and his wife took me under their wing. They became like my second parents. On my birthday, they even gifted me a brand-new bicycle. That was a huge deal for me at the time," he says.

To this day, he calls them 'Mom' and 'Dad,' and they remain in touch. "They used to tell people at church,

'Our son is going to do very well in life.' Their faith in me meant a lot," he shares.

Taher balanced his studies and was not afraid of hard work, and he never let his circumstances define him. The US offered him exposure to cutting-edge technology, a fast-paced corporate culture, and a chance to dream bigger than ever before.

Graduating into a recession

In 1991, after two years of rigorous study and constant hustling, Taher graduated with his master's degree in computer science engineering, which was welcomed by a recession in the US, which had slowed down hiring drastically. "I was told that if you send out 100 applications, maybe two companies will respond," he recalls.

With no degree from an Ivy League school, Taher knew the odds were stacked against him. But when the going gets tough, the tough get going. Taher sent out 200 applications and heard back from a startup called HAL Computer Systems. It was not the big-name company he had hoped for, but it was a foot in the door. After four months of working at HAL, he received a call from Intel. A step closer to his dreams, Taher knew that securing